

LIGHTING UNLIMITED × SHOPIFY

A self-serve B2B storefront — without leaving DDI behind

A branded, login-gated ordering portal where your contractors and accounts log in, see their own pricing, and place orders on their own — so counter sales scale without the phone calls and paper tickets.

Shopify Plus · B2B portal · DDI-integrated · 4 Arizona branches

OVERVIEW

Where Shopify fits

Lighting Unlimited is a lighting & electrical distributor serving the greater Phoenix Valley from four branches, with roughly 92% of sales B2B. The opportunity isn't a new sales team — it's giving the customers you already serve a faster way to buy.

The problem today

Nearly every order runs through a person — walk-ins, phone calls, and manually written tickets on a pre-coded pricing matrix. It works, but as the company scales, the overhead to handle all those manual transactions gets heavy. There's no online interface for the customers who just want to log in and re-order at their agreed pricing.

The goal

A branded, gated storefront (e.g. an LU-owned domain "powered by Shopify") where account customers log in to their own tier pricing and self-serve — while **DDI stays your source of truth** and the big, complex spec jobs stay exactly where they are.

Guardrail we'll respect: manufacturers (Acuity, Philips, Lutron, Minka, etc.) restrict public online listing. Everything sits **behind a login on your own branded site** — not on a public marketplace — which keeps you inside your buying-group and channel agreements.

CURRENT STATE

How it works right now

A quick map of today's stack and the three ways customers buy — so we only rebuild what's worth rebuilding.

Systems today

- **ERP:** DDI (distributor ERP) — stays the system of record; you may evaluate NetSuite down the line
- **E-commerce:** none currently (previous site retired); manual listings on Amazon & eBay, low volume
- **Payments:** a separate card processor (buying-group negotiated rates); most sales are on terms / AR
- **Buying group:** Affiliated Distributors — channel & pricing agreements to preserve

Three ways customers buy

- **Counter & pop-up pricing** — walk-in / phone, pre-coded tier pricing. ← **the best fit to move online**
- **Outside sales / spec jobs** — complex quotes, large POs (e.g. \$100k retrofits). Stays in DDI
- **Municipal / contract** — blanket POs & pre-negotiated annual pricing; one city requires an online PO portal

Pricing complexity

Tiers today are bronze / silver / gold, moving toward a cleaner bronze / silver / gold / platinum model — with customer-category modifiers (electrician vs. general contractor vs. property management). Net terms (net 30 / 45 / 60) are common. This tier count is the main thing that decides the plan (below).

USE CASES

What we'd build on Shopify

Straight from our conversation — mapped to Shopify B2B capabilities. Core = we'll validate feasibility in the technical discovery.

Self-serve ordering

CORE

Account customers log in and place their own orders at their agreed pricing — no phone call or counter visit required.

Login-gated catalog

CORE

Products visible only after login on your branded site — protects manufacturer channel rules and buying-group agreements.

Customer-specific pricing & tiers

CORE

Catalogs & price lists per company/tier (bronze→platinum) plus category modifiers, driven by who's logged in.

B2B payment terms

CORE

Net 30 / 45 / 60 and pay-on-account, so online ordering matches how your customers already pay.

Municipal / contract portal

CORE

Upload pre-negotiated blanket pricing — covers the city that requires an online portal to cut POs.

DDI integration

CORE

Orders & fulfillment sync with DDI; outside-sales quotes handled as draft orders; complex jobs stay in DDI.

Payments & Shop Pay

COMPARE

Shopify Payments unlocks Shop Pay; or keep an approved third-party processor (+~0.2% on Plus). We'll compare vs. your buying-group rate.

In-store POS

OPTIONAL

Unify counter sales across the four branches on Shopify POS later — weighed against your current processor's value.

Explicitly out of scope for now: the large, complex spec/quote jobs and \$100k POs — those stay in DDI. Shopify targets the repeatable counter & account ordering that eats the most manual time.

PLANS & PRICING

Shopify Plus

Your model — four pricing tiers with category modifiers, net payment terms, municipal contract pricing and a login-gated catalog — needs the full B2B suite. That points to **one plan: Shopify Plus**. The core plans cap catalogs and price lists and can't handle this pricing structure.

YOUR PLAN

Shopify Plus

\$2,300 /mo base

At ~\$19M B2B revenue you're above the ~\$7.9M threshold, so billing runs on the Variable Platform Fee — **~\$2,850/mo effective** (see below). Full B2B suite, built for your pricing model.

- **Unlimited** companies, customer catalogs & price lists
- **Tiered pricing** — bronze / silver / gold / platinum + category modifiers
- **Net payment terms** (net 30/45/60) & pay-on-account
- Login-gated B2B storefront + wholesale & D2C on one store
- Municipal / contract catalogs with pre-negotiated pricing
- Draft orders, checkout customization, expansion stores

Payments

Shopify Payments — standard cards	2.25% + 30¢
Shopify Payments — Amex	2.95% + 30¢
Approved third-party processor (keep yours)	+ ~0.2% on Plus

Platform cost at your volume

You pay the **higher of** the \$2,300/mo base or the Variable Platform Fee (VPF). At **~\$19M in revenue** you're above the ~\$7.9M threshold, so VPF applies — and it's charged by channel. Because you're **~92% B2B**, the rate that matters is the lowest one:

B2B — your primary channel	0.18%
Retail (POS)	0.25%
D2C (online)	0.35%
Effective platform cost — B2B 0.18% × ~\$19M	≈ \$34,200/yr (~\$2,850/mo)

Total cost of ownership

Two buckets: a **one-time build** with Solo Media, and your **ongoing Shopify Plus** platform. Plus fees and apps are billed to you directly by Shopify; Solo Media invoices the build against milestones. Shopify handles hosting, security and upgrades — no servers on your side.

One-time — Solo Media build	\$30,000–
SOW SMG-2026-LU-001 · B2B portal + DDI integration + WordPress migration	\$35,000
Milestones at \$35K draft — 40% kickoff / 35% portal + DDI / 25% launch	\$14,000 / \$12,250 / \$8,750
Shopify Plus platform — VPF 0.18% × ~\$19M B2B	≈ \$34,200/yr (~\$2,850/mo)
Apps (e.g., Matrixify for the DDI/CSV sync) — billed via Shopify	~\$50–200/mo est.
Year 1 total — platform + build + apps	≈ \$64,200–\$69,200 + apps
Year 2+ ongoing — platform + apps	≈ \$34,200/yr (~\$2,850/mo) + apps
Monthly view — Year 1 blended (build included)	~\$5,350–\$5,770/mo → ~\$2,850/mo after

Solo Media SOW #SMG-2026-LU-001 is a draft: the current \$35,000 figure assumes a scheduled CSV/Matrixify DDI sync (range \$30K–\$35K); if DDI exposes API endpoints for a real-time integration, Solo Media confirms any adjustment before an executed SOW. Includes 30 days of post-launch defect fixes; ongoing dev at \$150/hr or a monthly retainer. Shopify POS is a separate future phase. Platform figure based on ~\$19M B2B at the 0.18% VPF rate; card rates & incentives confirmed on the order form.

NEXT STEPS

The path to launch — a Sept 30 start, live before year-end

Scope is locked in Solo Media's SOW, so this is a clean **Sept 30 start** and an **8–12 week parallel build** — live comfortably before the holidays (and ahead of Jan 1). The **DDI integration** and the **B2B order-review workflow** are the pacing items: a CSV sync compresses toward 8 weeks; a real-time DDI API pushes toward 12.

● Today · Sept 21 — partner + SE working session

Walk the build. Solo Media reviews the plan and the DDI integration approach; the **Statement of Work (\$35,000 fixed, CSV-sync assumption)** is on the table. *Solo Media · Shopify SE · you.*

● Sept 22–24 · owner & CFO review

Take it up the chain. Harrison walks the plan + SOW to the owner and new CFO; feedback back to us **Tuesday or Wednesday**. *You.*

● On a green light · account + contract

We move fast. Nicole spins up your Shopify Plus account and sends the Plus agreement + Solo Media SOW to sign. *Shopify · Solo Media.*

● Sept 30 · start date

Sign & kick off. Execute the Plus agreement + SOW (40% / \$14,000 kickoff); signing locks the incentive. *You (sign) · all.*

● Weeks 1–2 · discovery & setup

Requirements workshop, DDI data mapping (products, pricing, inventory, images, customers), the **API-vs-CSV integration decision**, and the Plus store + dev store stood up. *Solo Media · Harrison.*

● Weeks 2–6 · the build

Storefront + **WordPress migration**, **B2B Companies & Catalogs** (tiered + SKU pricing), the **order-review workflow** (review gate + payment holds via Flow), and net-terms invoicing. *Solo Media.*

● Mid-build · DDI integration (the long pole)

Sync products, pricing, inventory & images + order write-back to DDI, with a **downtime queue** and customer-facing notification bar; on-demand customer-onboarding templates. *Solo Media · Harrison.*

🟡 Weeks ~7–10 · QA & training

End-to-end QA of the B2B + retail flows, then SOPs and live training so your team runs daily ops (CSV uploads, order review). *You · Solo Media.*

🟢 ~Late Nov – late Dec · launch & cutover

Go live on Shopify Plus. Full 301-redirect map, zero-downtime domain switch, post-launch stabilization. The CSV path lands ~late Nov; the API path ~late Dec — **before Jan 1** either way. *All.*

What we need from you

- Owner + CFO feedback by Tue/Wed (Sept 22–24)
- Green light to create your Shopify Plus account
- Sign the Plus agreement + Solo Media SOW by Sept 30 — locks the start date and the incentive
- Facilitate DDI access at kickoff — it's the pacing item that protects the date

Honest read: starting Sept 30, an 8–12 week build lands you live before year-end — even the real-time DDI API path (~12 weeks) finishes ahead of Jan 1. The two make-or-break items are **DDI access** (so the integration isn't blocked) and the **Sept 30 signature**. If DDI turns out heavier than scoped, we protect the date by launching the core portal first and adding the municipal portal / POS right after.

What your owner & CFO will likely ask — and the answer

- **"It works today — why spend?"** Your customers are asking to self-serve, you just won a city contract that requires an online portal, and this scales counter/phone volume without adding headcount.
- **"Is the DDI integration risky?"** Solo Media is a Shopify Platinum partner (500+ migrations, ERP integrations included). Worst case, we use the same CSV / scheduled-sync model you already run with SmartSheets — and DDI stays your source of truth.
- **"Do we have to rip out our POS / payment processing?"** No. Online-first; your DDI POS keeps running in parallel. In-store/POS is a later phase.
- **"Who maintains it — we have no IT?"** Shopify runs the platform (uptime, security, upgrades, servers). You edit content yourselves and Solo Media hands over documentation (optional retainer for ongoing custom work). Plus you get Shopify Plus support, a Customer Success Manager, and Nicole + Angel supporting you long-term.
- **"Timeline?"** Jan 1 is feasible — an OK from the owners this week, a Sept 30 signature/kickoff, and DDI as the critical path, so the sooner we start the safer the date.

How we help you prep: send over any concerns — or the specific hesitations you expect from your owner/CFO — and we'll help you prep the answers ahead of time. We're also glad to **join the owner conversation**, or be on **standby** to jump in and answer questions live.

Prepared by Nicole DeGennaro · Shopify — for Lighting Unlimited. Built from our intro call. B2B feasibility confirmed in technical discovery; pricing & scope finalized with an implementation partner.